

HOLIDAY COMPANION

El compañero navideño

The Nochebuena set: coquito, pernil, arroz con gandules, and tembleque — batched and timed.

Mainland-tested · From the Ortiz kitchen

Hecho con corazón y sofrito · sofritostudio.com

Coquito — Authentic Puerto Rican Coconut Holiday Drink Recipe

Coquito

Puerto Rico's coconut eggnog — the holiday drink that replaces everything from November through January. Every family has a secret recipe.

Ingredients

- 2 cans (13.5 oz) coconut milk
- 1 can (14 oz) sweetened condensed milk
- 1 can (12 oz) evaporated milk
- 1 cup white rum
- 1 teaspoon vanilla extract
- 1 teaspoon ground cinnamon
- Pinch of ground nutmeg

Steps

1. Pour all ingredients into a blender: coconut milk, condensed milk, evaporated milk, rum, vanilla, cinnamon, and nutmeg.
2. Blend on high for 1-2 minutes until completely smooth and frothy.
3. Taste and adjust — add more cinnamon for warmth, more rum for kick, or more condensed milk for sweetness.
4. Pour into glass bottles or jars. Refrigerate for at least 4 hours (overnight is better) to let the flavors meld.
5. Serve ice cold over ice, dusted with a generous sprinkle of ground cinnamon on top.

Pernil Asado — Slow-Roasted Puerto Rican Pork Shoulder Recipe

Pernil

Slow-roasted pork shoulder with crispy skin and garlicky mojo criollo. The Nochebuena centerpiece.

Ingredients

- 1 bone-in pork shoulder (8-10 lbs)
- 8 cloves garlic, mashed into a paste
- 1/4 cup olive oil
- 2 tablespoons dried oregano
- 1 tablespoon black pepper
- 1 tablespoon salt
- 2 tablespoons white vinegar
- 1/4 cup sofrito

Steps

1. Score the pork skin in a crosshatch pattern with a sharp knife, cutting through the fat but not into the meat.
2. Make the mojo criollo: mash garlic with oregano, pepper, salt, vinegar, olive oil, and sofrito into a thick paste.
3. Rub the paste all over the pork, working it under the skin and into every crevice.
4. Cover tightly and refrigerate overnight (at least 8 hours) to let the marinade penetrate.
5. Roast at 375°F for about 4 hours, basting every hour, until the internal temperature reaches 185°F and the skin is crackling-crispy.
6. Let rest for 20 minutes before carving. The juices redistribute and the skin stays crisp.

Arroz con Gandules — Authentic Puerto Rican Rice and Pigeon Peas Recipe

Arroz Con Gandules

Puerto Rico's national dish — rice, pigeon peas, and sofrito. The one-pot meal every boricua makes for holidays.

Ingredients

- 2 cups long-grain rice
- 1 can (15 oz) gandules (pigeon peas), drained
- 1/4 cup sofrito
- 2 tablespoons vegetable oil
- 1 packet sazón con culantro y achiote
- 1 teaspoon ground cumin
- 2.5 cups chicken broth
- 1/2 cup manzanilla olives with pimento
- Salt to taste

Steps

1. Heat oil in a large caldero or heavy pot over medium heat. Add sofrito and sauté for 2 minutes until fragrant.
2. Add drained gandules and cook for 3 minutes, stirring occasionally.
3. Stir in sazón and cumin. Cook for 1 minute to bloom the spices.
4. Add rice and stir to coat every grain in the sofrito mixture.
5. Pour in chicken broth, add olives, and bring to a boil. Stir once, then reduce heat to low.
6. Cover tightly and cook for 25 minutes without lifting the lid. Fluff with a fork before serving.

Tembleque — Puerto Rican Coconut Milk Pudding Recipe

Tembleque

A coconut milk pudding that literally jiggles — the holiday dessert on every Puerto Rican Christmas table.

Ingredients

- 2 cans (13.5 oz) coconut milk
- 1/2 cup cornstarch
- 1/2 cup sugar
- 1/4 teaspoon salt
- Ground cinnamon for dusting

Steps

1. In a small bowl, whisk the cornstarch with 1/2 cup of the coconut milk until completely smooth with no lumps. Set aside.
2. Pour the remaining coconut milk into a medium saucepan. Add the sugar and salt. Heat over medium, stirring occasionally, until it reaches a gentle simmer.
3. Whisk the cornstarch mixture one more time, then slowly pour it into the simmering coconut milk, whisking constantly.
4. Continue cooking and whisking for 3-5 minutes until the mixture thickens to a pudding consistency. It should coat the back of a spoon.
5. Pour into a mold, bundt pan, or individual cups. Let cool to room temperature, then cover and refrigerate for at least 4 hours until fully set.
6. To unmold, run a knife around the edges and invert onto a plate. Dust generously with ground cinnamon before serving.